



DOLA BANERJEE

Former Olympic archer and 2007 World Cup individual gold medal winner



CONSISTENCY KEY IN OLYMPIC YEAR

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Our archers did well in 2023 and showed improvement. Even though our recurve archers could not qualify for the Olympics through the World Championships, our men's and women's teams had top-eight finishes. It would help our world rankings and might help in booking our tickets to Paris 2024. We also had a good outing in the Asian Games, with both men's and women's teams winning medals after so many years.

So far, we have only one quota place, with B. Dhiraj claiming an individual spot. In 2024, we will get a chance to qualify through the continental event. We will have our rigorous selection trials, starting in Kolkata in January, before moving on to Pune and Sonapat.

Overall, several youngsters have come up nicely. They have been scoring well and winning medals. The competitiveness has increased. Archers are coming from every state, and the government support has been good.

The number of competitions has increased manifold. But there needs to be a limit to it, as too many competitions are not ideal as well.

Our archers need to be consistent. Especially the women need to raise their performance by scoring



Set the ball rolling: Dhiraj Bommadevara has opened India's Paris Olympic quota account in archery. GETTY IMAGES

better. We must keep in mind that archers from other countries who have not yet qualified will be highly motivated to win quota places. The women's team is a little short on experience as there is no senior archer to guide them in tough situations. You need to learn how to support each other.

Our compound archers have done exceptionally well. They have won gold medals in the World Championships and the Asian Games, which was unthinkable at one time. The Italian foreign coach, Sergio Pagni, has made a difference. We started compound archery very late in our country, but we have done well and are among the best in the world.

If we compare compound and recurve archery, the compound bow is much more mechanical, whereas the recurve bow is more manual. If one gets set with a compound bow, one can get good results in a short period. The recurve is much more technical, and the chances of mistakes creeping into one's game are very high.

The whole focus this year will be on qualifying for Paris 2024 and doing well in the Olympics. We have a Korean coach, Baek Woong Ki, and the recurve archers can tell how he is helping them build up for bigger challenges.

As told to Y.B. Sarangi.